

2026 AI Innovator in Education Award Submission:

Reimagining Skills-Based Learning with Custom GPTs

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Innovation & Originality

This project represents a shift in instructional design: repositioning AI from a tool for answer generation to a constrained coaching system that supports how students think and practice in skills-based learning environments.

MKT 310, Consultative Selling, is a skills-based course in which students complete a high-stakes, live sales role-play requiring an unscripted, real-time conversation across multiple stages of the sales process. While face-to-face students benefit from repeated practice and immediate coaching, online learners have traditionally relied on discussion boards designed to prepare them for role-plays. Although these assignments support reflection, they lack the real-time interaction, revision, and iterative skill development needed for live Zoom-based role plays.

To address this gap, I developed a series of six Custom GPTs aligned with the stages of the consultative sales process: Opening, Needs Identification (SPIN), Demonstrating Capability, Handling Objections, and Obtaining Commitment.

Unlike routine AI applications that prioritize efficiency, these tools are intentionally designed to slow students down. They function as structured decision trees and do not provide “correct answers.” Instead, they:

- Require students to generate unscripted responses
- Monitor process sequencing and interrupt when critical steps are skipped
- Provide targeted coaching prompts that explain the reasoning behind effective sales behaviors

By embedding this coaching logic, the GPTs simulate instructor intervention within a scalable, interactive environment. This transforms AI into a structured practice partner that reinforces reasoning, sequencing, and professional judgment rather than content production.

Demonstrated Impact on Students or Institutional Effectiveness

Prior to the implementation of Custom GPTs, online students often entered live role-play evaluations with gaps in sequencing, incomplete needs identification, and limited ability to adapt in real time. While discussion boards supported reflection, they did not provide sufficient opportunity for rehearsal, feedback, or real-time adjustment. Additionally, students increasingly used generative AI to produce discussion responses, which often lacked process logic and did little to develop the critical thinking skills required for live role play.

Following the introduction of the Custom GPT coaching framework, several consistent improvements have been observed:

- **Stronger process alignment:** Students demonstrate more intentional questioning and improved conversational flow during live evaluations.
- **Increased engagement:** Many students voluntarily repeat GPT-based practice, indicating active investment in skill development.
- **Deeper reasoning:** Responses reflect a stronger understanding of sequencing and decision-making logic.
- **More effective use of instructional time:** Feedback has shifted from correcting foundational errors to refining higher-level strategy.

Student reflections reinforce these outcomes, with many describing the GPTs as effective “practice partners” that help them think more intentionally during interactions. One student wrote, “This was actually great practice. I never would have thought to use ChatGPT to do a role-play.” Another reflected that the exercise helped them “think more intentionally about the conversation.”

The GPTs function as a structured decision-making framework that allows students to practice individual stages of the sales process before integrating them into a full role-play. This approach mirrors how complex professional skills are developed: through guided practice, immediate feedback, and iterative refinement.

As a result, students enter live role plays better prepared and more confident, with clearer evidence of skill transfer from practice to performance. From an instructional perspective, this redesign has improved the efficiency and quality of assessment. Instead of reviewing discussion posts that were often AI-generated and responses that were misaligned with course objectives, the GPT activities channel AI use into guided practice. This shift has moved my instructional focus from correcting foundational errors to refining higher-level reasoning and strategic thinking.

Illustrative Examples

The links to the custom GPT artifacts referenced below are in *Appendix A* for committee review.

Custom GPT 1: Opening the Sales Call Role Play

The Opening custom GPT focuses on introducing oneself, establishing rapport, and strategically transitioning into the meeting's purpose. Students frequently move too quickly into business or fail to develop relational cues introduced by the buyer. The GPT detects these missed opportunities and pauses the interaction with a coaching prompt before allowing the conversation to continue.

The following excerpt is from a student's submitted practice interaction this semester:

Student: Good morning, I'm Jane Jones (fictitious name) with Berry Global. How are you today?

Buyer (GPT): I'm doing well, though the snow has made it a chilly morning. My golden retriever, Milo, still insists on dragging me outside no matter how cold it gets.

Student: That's great. I'm here to see if I can help improve your packaging. Let me tell you more about Berry Global.

Buyer (GPT Coaching Nudge): I mentioned my golden retriever, Milo. That was a strong rapport hook. Before moving the meeting forward, ask a follow-up question about my dog.

This intervention reinforces active listening and conversational timing, requiring students to intentionally develop rapport before transitioning to business objectives.

Custom GPT 2: SPIN Question Needs Identification

The second custom GPT helps students apply the SPIN framework (Situation, Problem, Implication, and Need-payoff questions), a structured questioning model for uncovering customer needs. Rather than simply labeling questions as correct or incorrect, the GPT functions as an interactive decision tree. When students misclassify a question, they are guided through prompts in the decision tree that analyze intent and sequencing.

This tool addresses a common learning gap: students may memorize terminology but struggle to apply it. By requiring reasoning rather than recall, the GPT strengthens conceptual understanding and improves transfer to performance.

Custom GPT 3: Needs Identification Role Play

The Needs Identification GPT addresses the most cognitively demanding stage of the process. Students often jump prematurely to diagnosing barriers or proposing solutions without first understanding the buyer's plan or priorities.

The GPT slows the conversation and enforces logical sequencing.

The following excerpt is from a student's submitted practice interaction this semester:

Student: What kind of goals does Kemp Orchards have for this upcoming year?

Buyer (GPT): We are aiming to increase revenue by 12% and reduce costs by 6%.

Student: What exactly is keeping you from accomplishing these goals?

Buyer (GPT Coaching Response): That question jumps ahead. Before discussing barriers, it would be helpful to understand how we plan to achieve those goals. You might ask, "How do you plan to increase revenue this year?"

Rather than simply correcting the student, the GPT explains the reasoning behind the sequence. This reinforces analytical thinking and helps students internalize consultative logic rather than rely on memorized scripts.

Custom GPTs 4–6: Capability, Objection Handling, and Commitment Role Plays

The remaining custom GPTs reinforce process discipline across later stages of the sales call. The Demonstrating Capability GPT requires students to connect proposed solutions to previously identified needs, preventing generic feature-based responses. The Objection Handling GPT evaluates whether students acknowledge and clarify concerns before responding, reinforcing structured reasoning and emotional regulation under pressure. The Obtaining Commitment GPT begins with buyer interest and evaluates whether students articulate clear next steps, understand the decision-making process, and secure a specific follow-up. It reinforces that commitment is achieved through clarity and alignment rather than pressure.

Together, these tools ensure that each stage of the sales process builds logically on the previous one.

Scalability & Transferability

The design of this project is flexible and highly adaptable across disciplines. Any course that involves process-driven communication or applied skill development can replicate this model by identifying key stages and embedding structured coaching logic.

Potential applications include:

- Healthcare communication (patient intake, diagnosis conversations)
- Management training (conflict resolution, performance feedback)
- Career readiness (interview preparation and professional communication)

Because the GPTs provide consistent, individualized feedback without increasing instructor workload, this approach is particularly valuable in online, hybrid, and large-enrollment environments. Implementation requires minimal technical expertise and can be scaled across courses or institutions.

Ethical, Responsible, and Inclusive Use of AI

This project was designed with intentional attention to ethical use, academic integrity, and equitable access.

- **Promoting active learning:** The GPTs guide thinking rather than generate answers, reducing opportunities for misuse while increasing cognitive engagement
- **Transparency:** Students are informed about how the tools function and their role in the learning process
- **Inclusivity:** Online and non-traditional students receive immediate, individualized coaching that mirrors the support available in face-to-face environments
- **Human-centered assessment:** Final evaluation remains a live, human-to-human interaction, ensuring an authentic demonstration of skill

By embedding AI into structured practice rather than assignment completion, this approach aligns with best practices for responsible AI integration in higher education.

Alignment with Regional Workforce and Community Needs

This project prepares students for the communication and problem-solving demands of the workforce. Skills such as active listening, needs diagnosis, adaptability, and communication are directly transferable to all professional environments.

The consultative selling framework reflects real-world business practices, particularly in industries where relationship-building and solution-oriented thinking are essential. In addition, students gain experience using AI as a tool for reflection and skill development, preparing them to work effectively in AI-enabled workplaces.

Nominee Biography

Dr. Julie Johnson-Busbin is a Marketing Professor at Western Carolina University, where she has taught for over 30 years, specializing in consultative selling and buyer–seller relationships. Her teaching focuses on experiential, skills-based learning that prepares students for real-world professional interactions. Her research focuses on buyer–seller relationships, salesperson performance, and the impact of AI on business-to-business sales.

Appendix A:

- 1) [Custom GPT Link: Opening the Sales Call Role Play](#)
- 2) [Custom GPT Link: SPIN Question Needs Identification](#)
- 3) [Custom GPT Link: Needs Identification Role Play](#)
- 4) [Custom GPT Link: Demonstrating Capability Role Play](#) (students are provided a product presentation slide deck to be used with this Custom GPT).
- 5) [Custom GPT Link: Handling Objections Role Play](#)
- 6) [Custom GPT Link: Obtaining Commitment Role Play](#)